



PROJECT SYLPHIED

I'm overjoyed at seeing a 32-inch LCD TV connected to our Xbox 360 for one of this month's games to play. Well, I move my focus from the setup to the game title—Project Sylpheed—a space combat arcade game. We haven't seen a game from this genre for a while now, so I feel a bit of excitement building up and some curiosity.

I pop in the disc and all of a sudden I'm in the middle of a good looking CG movie with anime-styled characters—something like *Final Fantasy*. At the end of the cinematic, I decide to get the game going but I'm delayed by some more cut-scenes.

In the game, you play the role of one Katana Faraway, a pilot whose job it is to blow the enemy's ships and destroyers into kingdom come with your ship. To help you do this, you fly a small combat ship alongside your "comrades," who are of no

use other than screaming at you and keep whining about your higher-ups. You can have your vehicle upgraded with all kinds of weapons from simple machine guns to lasers and lock-on missiles that make mincemeat out of enemies.

The game looks nice—it's cramped with colourful exhausts and weapon rounds from all kinds of ships and space vehicles. The environment is made up well—empty space with stars scattered all over, and an occasional planet. The on-screen display is filled with statistics and pointers meant to lead you to enemies. There are speed meters and a hundred gazillion other things. This is both messy and scary when you first sit down to play this.

The controls are a little difficult in the beginning. The lock-on missiles make everything very easy, though. You hold down a key and manoeuvre your ship so you have your

enemy ship into the crosshairs till you get a lock-on. Let go of the key and the rockets will home into the ship, destroying it. The challenge comes in the form of numbers. The missions are quite long due to the masses of enemy ships. The entire gameplay is made up of you chasing one ship after the other—and that's it. This continues till a mission ends, after which certain weapons and achievements are unlocked. You can then add these to your ship before moving to the next mission.

The sounds of the ships are lacking considering it's an arcade game. There's some fairly decent character voice acting, but the music is just plain cheesy.

The game gets repetitive, and you end up using the same set of weapons and the same strategies over and over. It can provide satisfactory entertainment if played once and once

only. There is no multiplayer option either.

All said, it's good to have a space combat game around—something we PC gamers haven't had a chance to enjoy in a while—but then these games are best played on consoles or with a good gamepad, not a keyboard. Retro space-combat-lovers will find a fulfilling experience in *Project Sylpheed*. I can't call this game fun for everybody; it's not really deep, nor is it very interesting.

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